

Artificial Intelligence: For the Worst?

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Opinion Brief

You are sitting on your phone, scrolling through Instagram Reels or anything similar to the sort. Most of the creators you see, you may assume are human; they are not. Those are bots. The internet is dead and our planet will soon follow. Let me explain: AI as we know it is taking over every aspect of our lives. From daily tasks in the office to areas where learning is supposed to be done, AI does the thinking for all. This could lead to the worst. Artificial Intelligence is harming all disproportionately in 2 ways; firstly because AI is harming the environment in severe ways, and secondly because AI is harming those in the classrooms.

Artificial intelligence is harming the environment; and not in miniature ways. Nat Meysenburg, technologist at New America's Open Technology Institute explains, how “according to Meta’s numbers, training this large language model (LLM), the same kind of AI used for things like ChatGPT, produced an estimated 539 tons of carbon dioxide (CO₂). That is equivalent to the electricity used by more than 100 hundred average U.S. homes in a year. Training GPT-3, a predecessor of ChatGPT, is estimated to have used as much electricity as 177 homes.” Rapidly growing AI data centers use immense amounts of electricity, significantly increasing climate change (Meysenburg, April 2 2024). Artificial intelligence is harming not just those who happen to unfortunately live in areas with major AI data centers near them, but the entire world.

Artificial intelligence is not just harming the environment, but students as well. AI, being used in the educated system, harms in three ways: discrimination, cyber risks, and loss of critical thinking. Looking from the discrimination standpoint, AI, though intended to help plan lessons or create Individual Education Plans (IEPs) for those of the disabled, does the opposite. Current reviews have failed to address the perspective of students with disabilities, which prompts ethical concerns. For instance, AI could treat people with disabilities as outliers in the data and end up discriminating against them (Pierres, Christien, Schmitt-Koopmann, and Darvishy, 2024). And these people with disabilities not only have to deal with AI not being able to treat them as they were just like the others, they also risk their information being leaked from AI databases. AI systems often require vast amounts of personal data to function effectively, including students' academic records, behavioural data and even biometric information. This extensive data collection raises significant concerns about how this information is stored, used and protected. Inadequate safeguards can lead to data breaches, exposing sensitive student information to unauthorized parties and potentially resulting in identity theft or other forms of misuse (Clugston, 2024). AI severely harms not just those that deal with discrimination, but every single person who has even interacted with the database. But all these risks cannot be outweighed by

one critical thing: critical thinking. With AI doing everything that we need it to do, from math problems to writing English essays, the human brain isn't actually doing any work, meaning that the school that they are going to is practically useless.

Works Cited

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